# Get Up, Stand Up - Station 19 (Season 4, Episode 12)

**By Krista Vernoff**

**with contributions from Station 19's writing/support staff and cast**

*To be performed by white/black duo team – Dr. Lewis is black and could be played by an actor of any gender, all other characters are white.*

*NOTE: White actor should be prepared to play both masculine and feminine roles.*

***Characters:***

***Diane Lewis:*** *Black grief counselor. In the wake of national outcry after the murder of George Floyd, Captain Maya Bishop brings in Dr. Lewis to grief counsel the team.*

***Maya Bishop:*** *Current Fire Chief at Station 19 – a white woman who has worked her way up in the ranks. Ambitious but dealing with the aftereffects of childhood emotional and verbal abuse.*

***Travis Montgomery:*** *Mixed race (Chinese/White); openly gay*

***Andy Herrera:*** *Latina, her father was the former Fire Chief at Station 19. She is recently married to black firefighter Robert Sullivan.*

***Jack Gibson:*** *White male who grew up in the foster care system. He struggles with the concept of white privilege.*

## INTRODUCTION

***ACTOR 1:*** *Eight minutes and 46 seconds.*

***ACTOR 2:*** *That's how long a white Minneapolis police officer knelt on George Floyd's neck, while he was handcuffed and face down on the pavement, screaming out that he couldn't breathe.*

***ACTOR 1:*** *Floyd's murder on May 25, 2020, sparked a renewed effort against police brutality and systemic racism.*

***ACTOR 2:*** *In April 2021, ABC's* Station 19 *aired an episode hailed as one of the most powerful reflections of George Floyd's murder on television.*

***ACTOR 1:*** *In this selection we find 4 of Station 19's non-black first responders struggling to understand, empathize and cope with their own visceral responses as they work through their emotions with Counselor Dr. Diane Lewis.*

***TOGETHER:*** *Get Up, Stand Up by Krista Vernoff*

***ACTOR 2:*** *with contributions from Station 19's writing/support staff and cast.*

**MAYA:** *(Enters breezily)* Any takers?

**DR. LEWIS:** Just one, so far. And you. What? Sit.

**MAYA:** No, I'm not . . .

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**DR. LEWIS:** You're what? You're. . . You're. . . You're not grieving? You had a happy little firehouse where everyone was best friends and racial disparity was not a hot topic. And now? Everything has changed. Everything and nothing.

**MAYA:** I know fire. I mean, I'm the person that studies them for fun. But this fire. . . This fire is beneath our feet. It's built into every foundation. . . Our history, language, n-news coverage. It's everywhere. I mean, we vent fires to let out the hot smoke and gasses so that we can contain the fire, but I don't see how we can contain this, let alone put it out. And growing up, we were taught about Black history and the Civil Rights movement. We were taught to believe that they had beat it. And I think, on some level, that belief was still inside of me and I am so embarrassed saying that to you.

**DR. LEWIS:** Well, you were taught that in school. . . and probably also at home. And that teaching, it's the coal that keeps the fire hot. When I was a child and I learned about the Native American genocide, I pictured one small village. . . One small village of men with feathers in their hair who gave the white people turkey and then got mad that they wouldn't leave. Now, I pictured it because those were the literal pictures in my history books. And even though I knew that my people had been stolen from their homes and brought here chained up on ships, somehow, I believed that textbook. I was 35 years old when I learned that in 1492, Columbus sailed the ocean blue, and in the wake of that, millions upon millions of people who had been living here for 15,000 years were extinguished. And the ones who survived were fighting every day against a culture that still wants to pretend they don't exist. We learn when we learn. And the shame we feel at having taken so long to learn, well, that can be useful as long as we use it well. Once we know better, we have to do better.

**MAYA:** When I was 13, I ran cross country and track, and during the off-season, my dad would train a group of us girls who ran both. And he would push us too hard, and when I didn't hit a drill the way he wanted me to. . . he'd make me do it over and over and over until I would collapse on the ground. And my dad would leave me there, and one by one, my team

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members would lie down next to me. Face to the concrete, eyes on me, silent. Giving me space, but. . . also making sure I wasn't alone.

And my instinct is that that is what I have to do for the Black members of my team... To quietly show up and let them know that I support them. But I think that instinct is wrong, because when my friends and I were 13, we didn't have the capacity to stand up against an abusive power. And now I do. I. . . I have the power to stand up and say when something is wrong. I mean, I have the power to call out injustices when I see them. I have. . . the power to make sure that everyone can breathe.

I want to tell everyone that I support them attending the protests. I want to go. I don't want to silently support anymore. I want to scream in the streets. *(beat)* But The Department won't like it. *(Sighs)* I'm on a track, and if I support this publicly. . . Which everything in me wants to do. . . It'll take me off that track.

Firefighters work with the police, okay? They're our brothers, too, and there are some bad apples, bu. . . after we all saw the horrific video, why aren't all the brothers. . . Why aren't all the friends. . . Why isn't every member of the police force in the streets demanding systemic change? Why? Because it'll take them off of the track.

****** Scene*******

**DR. LEWIS:** *(Travis enters, stands awkwardly. He is visibly upset, then attempts to leave)* You know, the Department pays me no matter what, but, uh, there's only so many crossword puzzles I can do, so. . . *(Laughs)* You want to talk?

**TRAVIS:** Oh, no. I mean, I. . . I want to let the Black firefighters go first.

**DR. LEWIS:** Do you see a line outside this door? I-I know the past couple months can't have been easy for you, either. Hate crimes are hate crimes, no matter the race.

**TRAVIS:** My mom got, uh. . . Well, she was spit on at the grocery store. . . Mm . . . the same day that George Floyd. . . My, uh. . . My mom was leaving, and a crazy maskless woman was like. . . "If this Kung Flu is real, it's because of people like her. The woman both didn't believe COVID was real and was blaming my mom for it. *(Whimpers)* When my mom told me, it actually felt like my organs were melting. I was so hot with rage, you know,

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remembering the times when I was a kid, and, you know, people would say stuff to us. And then, we would just go home. Never to be discussed again. And I. . . And I didn't say anything to anyone here about it because, you know, it didn't feel appropriate. This giant, massive thing was happening. . . A hate crime. *(Whimpering; sobbing)* An atrocity so much more brutal and egregious. You know, other people were hurting so much more. I'm sorry. I don't know why I'm talking to you about this. I don't know why I'm doing that.

**DR. LEWIS:** Because I'm a Black woman, and my racist stuff is "bigger"? That doesn't work. *(beat)* I know that since COVID, hate crimes against Asian Americans have spiked like crazy.

**TRAVIS:** And yet, no one is talking about it. . . No one but us. Not the media. Not the. . . *(Scoffs)* I mean, grandmas and grandpas. . . *Halmoni* and *haraboji*. People being shoved into walls and off subway platforms. You have Filipina nurses who say goodbye to their families and their own country to come here to work the front lines of a pandemic being attacked in the streets. A 2-year-old and a 6-year-old stabbed at a big-box store. I mean, who stabs a 2-year-old? And why is that not news? Why are we so. . . invisible?

**DR. LEWIS:** I don't know. I. . . *(Sighs)* I don't know.

**TRAVIS:** I don't know either! But how can we even make a fuss when this is all it is relative to how horrifically this country treats Black people? I mean, I watched that whole video, and in addition to the absolute horror that I felt. . . And feel. . . I also thought. . . "What do we have to even complain about?"

**DR. LEWIS:** Travis, it's all bad. I know you're trying to be generous, but it is all bad. There are no winners in the Oppression Olympics. Okay? And it's gaslighting if anyone tells you or if you tell yourself to be okay with the brutalities being inflicted on your community because worse things are happening to another. *(Sighs)*

*****Scene*****

**ANDY:** *(Enters with a heavy sighs, she gathers her thoughts then burst out angrily)* You know, it's always bothered me when men would suddenly see the world differently after they had a daughter. Like, I always wondered why it took them having a daughter in order to open their eyes. But I guess that's how it feels for me now. I'm that guy. *(Exhales*

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*sharply)* The world changed for me because I fell in love with a Black man, and now I see what he sees. You know, I . . . I worry for him every day. I-I've taken on the fear that he doesn't allow himself to feel.

I. . . You know, I've always seen it and felt it growing up. I saw my dad go through it. People would call him awful names, and he would. . . He would just walk by, hold his head up high. A-As a kid, people would look at my last name, and they would ask me, "Where are you really from?" *(Scoffs)* I even had teachers who would look really surprised once they realized that I was smart. But, you know, mostly. . . *(Clicks tongue)* *(Scoffs)*

**DR. LEWIS:** It's okay to say it.

**ANDY:** Mostly, I got treated okay because my skin is light. I pass for white.

**DR. LEWIS:** And you feel guilty about that?

**ANDY:** *(Clicks tongue)* I. . . You know. . . *(Clears throat)* I swear to God, I don't even know how I feel. I feel. . . *(Stammers)* I feel betrayed. I mean, j. . . I know it's always been this way, but I needed to love a Black man. . . I needed to be married to a Black man. . . in order to see the whole picture? Why? Why? Where was my call for justice? Like, why didn't I see this before? W. . . Why am I just waking up now?

**DR. LEWIS:** A lot of people are waking up now, and they're asking themselves the same questions. And you. . . You're the daughter of a fire captain. Police have been a part of your life since you were a little girl. Cops and firefighters were your family.

**ANDY:** They would call me *Pruitita*. It means Little Pruitt. And there was this sort of mental gymnastics going on where, a-as I got older, I thought I knew that police brutality was rampant. But at the same time, I didn't count the cops that I knew personally into that issue. You know, it was double-think. Like, I never stopped and questioned why the good cops weren't calling out the bad ones. You know, not a single one of my dad's old police friends have stepped forward to denounce the actions of the officers that murdered George Floyd? Not a single one.

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**DR. LEWIS:** It is my instinct as a therapist to comfort you, but your comfort. . . and everyone else's comfort. . . has been such a big part of this problem for so long. *(Sighs)*

*****Scene*****

**JACK:** *(Enters sheepishly)* I'm sorry. I'm sure I'm not the one you're here to talk to.

**DR. LEWIS:** I'm here to talk to anyone who needs it.

**JACK:** I'm afraid to talk to anyone right now. Not just you. . . T-to anyone. I'm afraid I'm gonna get every word wrong, or even one word. Yeah, I know I'm not a racist. Ohh. I-I know that.

**DR. LEWIS:** You do realize that "I'm not racist" is kind of the. . . the club slogan of racists? And that's because we live in a culture built on white supremacy, so the racism is baked in. And we can't begin to undo it until we name it and own it.

**JACK:** *(frustrated)* Okay, see, this is exactly my point. You know, I'm damned if I do, and I'm damned if I don't. Cops take a knee, join the protests, they're called hypocrites. But it can't be that across the board.

**DR. LEWIS:** Jack, you came in here today looking for some clarity. So, here it is. I know what you mean when you say you aren't racist, and I believe that you do not have hatred in your heart. But you also aren't damned. Not even in the least bit. You're blessed as hell. I know you grew up on the streets in the system, and I'm not diminishing your hardship, but you are . . .

**JACK:** Yeah, I'm privileged because I'm white. I get it. When I was a kid. . . After that last foster home, there were a few of us who would hunker down to make a place for ourselves. . . squatting. You know, to stay out of the system. Eventually, the cops would find us, and we'd run. And it was scary. But when I was being chased, not once did I think that, "If he catches me, he might kill me." I never feared for my life. But I know some of my friends did. I know I'm privileged, Diane. I watched that video, and I want to blow up the world.

And? And... we're firefighters. We need the cops, and they need us. And we can't all of a sudden overnight decide that the whole institution is evil. Some good guys stayed silent, and that makes them bad. Except, they're not actually all bad. They're individuals. And I feel like I'm not allowed to say that. I'm afraid to say anything. Mm. *(Inhales deeply)*

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**DR. LEWIS:** I was a firefighter, too. I have cop buddies, too. Our cop buddies are not the point. Do you know what the 13th Amendment did? Abolished slavery. Except as a punishment for a crime.

**JACK:** Yeah, but that was like. . .

**DR. LEWIS:** That's still the law. It is still legal to enslave Americans as a punishment for a crime. And do you know the statistics of incarcerated Black folks in America? 34%. We are 34% of the prison population, but we only make up 13% of this country's population. That seem right to you? And you're thinking, "Well, that's because more Black people are poor, so they have to resort to crime. So they get arrested more. Sucks for them, but, hey, you do the crime, you do the time." But how many crimes did you commit, Jack, when you were out there on the streets? Did you, uh, steal to eat? Did you run from police? Did you get drunk sometimes and make a mess with your friends?

**JACK:** Yeah, all of that.

**DR. LEWIS:** But you never went to prison. Never went to jail. Never had a gun pointed at you. Never have a knee put on your neck. When you make mistakes, you get to learn from them. When people who look like me make any kind of mistake, we go to prison. . . or worse. And way too often, no mistake is needed. We can laugh too loud and they'll arrest us. We can put our hands in the air, and they'll shoot us. It's not in the past. It's now. It's still. And I know you don't have hatred in your heart, Jack. But that's not enough anymore. You have to dig deeper. When you're too uncomfortable to talk and you don't know what to say? That's okay. Listen instead.

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## SOURCE INFORMATION

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